

Age Well: Garden of Life

A wellness-gamification concept inspired by Roblox’s *Grow a Garden*

1. Overview

Age Well: Garden of Life is a gentle, gamified wellness app that adapts the popular *Grow a Garden* farming-sim loop for older adults. The goal: make healthy daily habits — movement, hydration, nutrition awareness, and mental engagement — feel rewarding rather than like a chore, using the same satisfying plant-grow-harvest loop that made the original game a hit.

2. Core Gameplay Loop

- Quiz to Earn** — Players answer short quizzes (health, wellness, general trivia) to earn in-game Coins. Doubles as light cognitive stimulation: memory recall, health literacy.
- Gacha Seeds** — Coins are spent on a seed gacha pull. Keeps things fun and replayable through anticipation and variety.
- Plant & Grow** — Seeds are planted to expand and beautify the garden — a visual record of consistency over time.
- Daily Quests (Pokémon GO-style)** — Real-world activity goals unlock in-game rewards, e.g.:
 - “Walk 1,000 steps → unlock a special seed.”
 - “Take a photo of a real bush or plant near you → unlock a matching rare seed.” (mirrors Pokémon GO’s photo/AR-style tasks, gently encouraging players to step outside and notice nature, with no pressure to identify or be correct about the plant)
- Water Reminders** — Push notifications prompt players to drink water in real life *and* water their virtual plants — pairing a real hydration habit with an in-game task. Neglected plants wilt, mirroring the real consequence of skipping water.
- Meal Achievements** — Once a player has harvested the full ingredient set for a simple recipe, a **Meal Card** auto-unlocks — showing the recipe name, a real-world version of it, and its nutritional benefit. This rewards growing a *variety* of crops instead of repeatedly farming one profitable crop, and quietly reinforces balanced eating. Completing a meal gives a bigger bonus (Coins, a decorative item, or a rare seed) than harvesting the ingredients alone.

Example Meals:

Meal	Ingredients Needed	Health Angle
🥗 Garden Salad	Spinach + Tomato + Carrot	Fiber, vitamins A/C/K — heart & eye health
🍲 Hearty Soup	Sweet Potato + Garlic + Legumes	Immune support, digestion
🥑 Omega Bowl	Walnuts/Flax + Whole Grain +	Brain & heart health

	Tomato	
🍪 Bone-Health Bake	Calcium Blossom + Sweet Potato	Bone density, fall prevention
🍉 Summer Refresher	Hydration Melon + Berries	Hydration + antioxidants

3. Why This Works — Impact on Aging Well & Society

Mechanic	Individual Benefit	Broader Societal Impact
Quizzes	Cognitive engagement, memory recall, health literacy	Lower population-level risk of cognitive decline; more informed health decisions reduce strain on care systems
Gacha seeds	Safe, bounded dose of delight and anticipation	Offers a healthier alternative to isolating or passive screen time common among older adults
Planting & growing	Sense of purpose, routine, visible progress	Linked to reduced depression/anxiety — supporting mental health at a population scale, not just individually
Step & photo-based daily quests	Encourages physical activity and time outdoors	Physical activity is one of the strongest protective factors against frailty, falls, and chronic disease — reducing long-term healthcare costs
Water reminders (real + virtual)	Reinforces hydration, a common gap in older adults	Dehydration is a major, preventable cause of hospitalization in seniors — small daily nudges can meaningfully cut this risk
Meal Achievements	Encourages varied, balanced eating	Supports better nutrition outcomes at scale, which can reduce diet-related chronic disease burden
Social/family features (challenge modes, shared gardens)	Emotional connection, motivation	Combats social isolation — one of the biggest known risk factors for both mental and physical decline in aging populations

The bigger picture: as populations age globally, low-cost, scalable tools that nudge daily healthy behavior — without requiring clinics, staff, or high cost — can meaningfully ease pressure on healthcare and caregiving systems. A game that’s genuinely fun to play, rather than something seniors are told to use, has a much better shot at real, sustained adoption — which is where the actual societal impact comes from.